Massachusetts Institute of Technology

Guide to Interviewing

Updated for the 2025–2026 Application Cycle

Welcome to your role as an Educational Counselor (EC) for MIT!

Your contributions play a vital role in identifying exceptional students who align with MIT's mission and values. This guide provides helpful tips for conducting interviews and writing insightful interview reports.

Support is also available from the EC office, your Regional Chairperson (RC), and through additional training materials listed at the end of this guide.

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1. Why We Interview

Interviews Serve Three Main Purposes:

- **Humanizing MIT** – showcasing MIT's positive aspects and clarifying misconceptions.
- **Gathering valuable information** – providing the admissions team with insights into an applicant's personal qualities, context, and match with MIT.
- **Offering guidance** – giving students a more personal, in-depth understanding of MIT.

What We're Looking for in Applicants

While strong grades and test scores are essential, admissions officers have that information on the application. The interview provides value in understanding the applicant's **match** with MIT.

There is no perfect applicant. We're looking for individuals who embody key attributes in three main areas:

Engagement and Joyfulness and Love for Learning

- **Initiative** — Have they made the most of opportunities? How might they take advantage of MIT's resources?
- **Risk-taking** — Do they embrace challenge and learn from failure?
- **Intensity, curiosity, and excitement** — Are they genuinely invested in the things that mean something to them? Will they put their heart into what they care about at MIT?

Match with MIT

- **Alignment with MIT's Mission** — How have they made the world better in both big and small ways? How do they want to leverage an MIT education for good in the future?
- **Hands-on creativity** — Do they enjoy not only thinking but also doing? Will they engage in making, building, and active learning at MIT?

Personal Qualities and Community Contributions

- **Collaborative and cooperative spirit** — Do they enjoy working with others and supporting group success? Will they thrive in MIT's problem-set study groups, team projects, and labs?
- **Active community members** — How have they contributed to the communities they are a part of? Will they be connected to communities at MIT?
- **The ability to prioritize balance** — Have they managed their time effectively in the past? Will they be able to manage their time and find ways to relax and have fun at MIT?

2. Who Can Be an EC

Eligibility Requirements

- All ECs must be an MIT undergraduate or graduate alum.
- Conflicts of interest, real or perceived, will inform the representative's eligibility. Such conflicts include:
    - ECs whose work involves college admissions cannot interview applicants while employed in that field. Examples include college admissions officers, school guidance counselors, independent college counselors, and college preparation consultants.
    - Secondary institution employees cannot interview students in their school district.
    - An EC who is the immediate family member of a current college applicant or lives in the same household as a current college applicant cannot interview any applicants the year their student applies, regardless of whether the applicant is applying to MIT or not.
- ECs May not represent another undergraduate institution in the same cycle.

Contact the EC office or your Regional Chairperson if you are unsure about your eligibility.

You'll make a great EC if you are:

- Friendly, approachable, and engaging.
- Aligned with MIT's mission to use science and technology to make the world a better place.
- Knowledgeable and up to date on MIT.
- Willing to serve as a resource to students and their communities.
- A nice, helpful person!

3. Key Dates and Deadlines

The specific dates vary each cycle, but this is a general calendar:

Summer - Focus on Training

- June through September — EC training and focused EC recruitment
- August through September — EC/VC/RC meetings and training sessions
- September — MIT hosts Alumni Leadership Conference

Fall - Focus on Early Action (EA) Interviewing

- End of August — First-year application available
- Mid-October — EA Applicants start to be assigned to ECs, interviews begin
- November 1st — EA application deadline
- Mid-November — Quest Bridge Interview reports due
- Mid- to Late November — EA Interview reports due
- Mid-December — EA decisions released

Winter - Focus on Regular Action (RA) Interviewing

- Mid-December — RA Applicants start to be assigned to ECs, interviews begin
- Early January — RA application deadline
- Mid-February — RA Interview reports due
- Mid-March — RA decisions released

Spring - Focus on Yield Events

- Late March — Local admitted student gatherings organized by RC/VCs
- Mid-April — Campus Preview Weekend
- Early May — Admitted students enrollment decisions due
- Early to Mid-May — Admissions decides on Waitlisted Applicants
- May — EC Report Ratings emailed to all ECs

4. The Interview Process

All work as an EC is done online via the EC Portal. You log in using your Alumni Account.

If you haven't used the portal before, the EC portal guide located on the Resources tab will help you navigate its features.

Getting Started

- Sign the **Best Practices Agreement** (required each year) on the portal.
- Set your status to **"Active"** on the **My Info** tab.
- Choose your **interview limit** on the **My Info** tab.
    - Default: 4 interviews for Early Action (EA), 5 for Regular Action (RA).
    - For new ECs, we recommend 3 interviews for EA and 4 for RA .
    - You can adjust the limit based on your availability. On average, each applicant requires about 3 hours to schedule, conduct the interview, and submit a report.
- Want to interview outside your region?
    - Sign up as an **Overflow Interviewer** on the same tab.

Applicant Assignments

- You'll receive an **automatic email** when an applicant is assigned to you.
    - EA assignments: October/November (and possibly December)
    - RA assignments: December/January (and possibly February)
- If you want to take on more interviews, check the **Overflow** tab in the portal.
    - Assign yourself applicants using a dropdown next to the student's name.
- Avoid **conflicts of interest.** If you're assigned to an applicant you know, contact your **Regional Coordinator (RC)** or the **EC Office** for reassignment.

Scheduling the Interview

- The applicant email notification includes a **template email** to contact the applicant. You can also find the template on the Resources tab on the portal.
- Interviews must be held in a **safe and public place**—not in your home or workplace.
- Offer a **few different time options** and schedule a time that works for both of you.
- Interviews can be **in-person or virtual**.
- Please **reach out promptly** after being assigned.
- Attempt to reach the applicant by email **twice**.
- If the applicant does not reply to your emails, you can send them a text message. This is an optional step but can get, more replies than emails.

Logging Interactions

- Please **log all interactions** in the portal to keep the EC office up to date on the status of the interview.
    - Reached Out —log when you first reach out to the applicant
    - Reached Out 2 — log if you reach out a second time. ECs are only expected to reach out to applicants twice.
    - Scheduled interview — log when you agree on a time with the student.
    - Conducted — log when the interview is done.
    - No Response — log if the applicant hasn't responded after two attempts.
    - Student Refused – log if the student declines the interview after contact.

Conducting the Interview

- Keep it **conversational**. Learn about the student and answer their questions about MIT.
- Aim for about **1 hour** (30 minutes to 2 hours is okay).
- MIT interviews are **casual**—no need for the student to dress up.
- Focus on creating a **positive, respectful and friendly** environment.

5. Interview Tips

Do

- Review training materials before your interview.
- Meet in a public place like a coffee shop or library (not your home or workplace).
- Help the student feel comfortable. Let them know it's a two-way conversation.
- Encourage them to ask questions.
- Let the student do most of the talking.
- Speak in English.
- Keep the conversation appropriate—use respectful language and stay on appropriate topics.
- Take notes to help with writing your report later.
- Keep everything confidential, including anything shared by MIT or the student—even the fact that the interview happened, or which high school the student attends.

Don't

- Research the student before the interview—let your impressions come from the conversation.
- Ask for documents like transcripts, essays, resumes, or applications.
- Give tests or puzzles—this is a conversation, not a quiz.
- Give opinions or comments on their chances of admission.
- Ask where else they're applying or whether MIT is their top choice. Keep the focus on MIT - don't compare colleges.
- Record the interview.
- Bring up personal topics like religion, race, sexual orientation, politics, income, or residency status. If the student brings these up on their own, it's okay to listen but be respectful and sensitive.

Handling Sensitive Topics

If a student appears uncomfortable with a topic, please move on and note it in your interview report if needed. Remember, there's an inherent power dynamic in interviews, and students may feel pressured to engage even when they're uneasy.

Avoid debates, especially on sensitive topics like politics or religion, as they don't serve the purpose of the interview. While differing opinions are okay, your role is to understand the student's experiences and provide information about MIT—not to challenge their beliefs. If a conversation starts to veer into debate, gently redirect it and continue with more relevant questions.

6. Sample Interview Questions

There's no required question list—let the conversation flow naturally. Below are some tips:

Introductory Questions

Try to learn a little about the background of the student. Ask questions, but if a student seems uncomfortable or gives a vague answer, you don't need to probe – move on and make a note in the report.

Some examples of introductory things to learn:

- Who are they? Where do they live?
- Who are their family members? Who do they live with?
- Where do they go to school?

General Approach to the Interview

Ask a broad question, then follow up to go deeper. You can repeat this process for projects, courses, activities and any other questions you ask.

For example:

- First, ask: *"Tell me about a recent group project."*
- Then ask:
  - *What did you enjoy about it?*
  - *What was challenging?*
  - *What role did you play?*
  - *How would you do it differently if you did the project again?*

Other Effective Questions

- What's a typical day like for you?
- Tell me about your high school. If you could change one thing, what would it be?
- Tell me about your community.
- What's your primary academic interest, and how did it start?
- What accomplishment are you most proud of?
- Who or what has influenced you most?
- What world problem would you most like to solve?
- What would you do with unlimited time and resources?
- Why MIT? What excites or concerns you about it?
- What's one question you wish I had asked?

7. Rating the Applicant

In your interview report, you'll rate the student in **three subcategories** on a **1–5 scale** and then give an **overall rating.**

Note that the three subcategories highlight the same criteria in the "What we are looking for" section on page 2 of this Guide.

Rating Categories

Engagement, Joyfulness and Love for Learning	Match with MIT	Personal Qualities and Community Contributions
We're looking for: **Initiative** **Risk-taking** **Intensity, curiosity, and excitement**	*We're looking for:* **Alignment with MIT's Mission** **Hands-on creativity**	*We're looking for:* **Collaborative and cooperative spirit** **Active community members** **The ability to prioritize balance**
Questions to consider: Does the student show curiosity, motivation, initiative, and passion? Are they self-driven, take risks, and make the most of opportunities?	*Questions to consider:* Is the student excited about MIT? Do they enjoy solving problems in a hands-on way? Do they use science and technology to help others?	*Questions to consider:* Would the student contribute to the MIT community? Have they worked with others effectively in the past?

Overall Rating

Your overall impression of how strong a candidate this student is for MIT.

Rating Scale (1–5)

5 – Exceptional	One of the best students you've ever interviewed. A perfect fit. Brings up strong examples of everything we are looking for.
4 – Outstanding	Highly recommended for admission. In the top 10% of students you've interviewed. Meets most of the criteria.
3 – Solid	A strong, average MIT applicant. Would be a good admit. Meets some of what we are looking for.
2 – Below Average	Weaker than most MIT applicants. Meets few traits we are looking for.
1 – Not Recommended	You don't think this student is a good fit for MIT.

Important Notes

- Many applicants are exceptional—**use the full scale**. A 3 or 4 is **not** a bad rating.
- Always consider **context**: family background, school, community, personal challenges, and what makes their achievements meaningful.
- **Plus One:** In addition to the 1-5 rating scale, you can choose to rate an applicant "plus one." This should be a rare score reserved for students you think are an exceptional match for MIT. You do not need to award a "plus one" every year.

8. Interview Report Guidelines

Format & Structure

- Style: Narrative, not a transcript of the interview
- Length: 4–6 paragraphs
    - Interviews that go more in-depth will likely yield longer reports
- To make the review of the report easier, put an extra line between paragraphs.

What to Include

- Mention your familiarity (or lack thereof) with the student's school or community.
- Summarize your view of the student using examples from the conversation.
- Detail the aspects that sparked the student's enthusiasm during the interview. Where did their personal qualities stand out? Explain why they are a good match for MIT.
- Motivation and Context - Explain *why* the student made certain choices. This will help us understand their circumstances.
- Support your ratings - explain why you gave the applicant high or low scores clearly.
- Be specific - a few detailed stories will go much further than a list of extracurriculars and achievements.

Optional Structures

- By topic (e.g., academics, hobbies, future plans)
- By key traits (e.g., leadership, initiative)
- By rating categories (e.g., engagement, personal qualities)

Writing a Difficult Report

Occasionally, you might have trouble writing an interview report because the student was quiet or you didn't "click. In these cases:

- Describe your efforts to connect.
- Be factual: "gave one-word answers" is better than just "nervous."
- If needed, write:
  "Based on my conversation with this student, I don't feel that I have gained enough information to write a full narrative. I've included brief notes below."
- This type of interview is rare.

9. After the Interviews

Decisions

- ECs will receive an email from the Admissions Office with the EA/RA decision dates.
- After a student has viewed their decision, it will be made available to you the next day on the Interview tab of the EC portal.
- You are welcome to reach out to admitted students to offer your congratulations!
- Please do not reach out to deferred or denied applicants. If these students reach out, you should direct them to our website, where we'll have specific blogs for deferred and denied applicants.

Wait List

- Each year Admissions determines if there is space to admit students off the waitlist.
- Once a decision is made (usually by mid-May), we will notify ECs via email with an update.

Admitted Student Gatherings

- In many regions, RCs, VCs, and ECs host informal gatherings for admitted students and their families.
- These events are critical to MIT's yield (the percentage of admitted applicants who enroll at MIT), providing our admitted students with an opportunity to personally meet and talk to MIT students, parents, and alumni.
- If your region holds an event, your RC will communicate the details.

On the ~4.5% Acceptance Rate

One of the most challenging parts of being an EC is the fact that MIT has such a low acceptance rate. Most students you interview will be exceptional applicants, and most will be denied. This is an unfortunate outcome of the limited space we have at MIT.

There are other reasons to interview, even if none of your applicants get admitted.

- Engage with the best of the younger generation - you’re talking to the future!
- Share your love for MIT and for using STEM to improve the world
- Meet the world – you can interview overflow applicants from all over
- Meet your own community – you can learn what your local students are doing
- Inspire students to dream big – even if they don’t end up at MIT
- MIT Admissions makes use of your report even if the student is not admitted (or if the decision is opposite of your recommendation)

10. Useful Links and Resources

- Portal Guide – How to use the EC Portal
- Best Practices Agreement – EC expectations and eligibility
- Sample Reports – See examples of strong (and average) interview writeups on the Resources tab of the portal
- Video Trainings – Interviewing tips and report writing
- Contact the EC office – Reach out to the EC Office: ecquestions@mit.edu
- Contact your RC – Find your RC's contact info on the portal homepage.